such assessments take place in the context of communities that have long been deliberately using this knowledge to handle and deploy ordnance in order to protect their assets. Communities' interaction with explosive devices is not a sign of ignorance, but is evidence of learned local practices grounded in militarized norms formed by social, political, and economic interactions.

For many communities in Myanmar landmine use presents an unenviable choice between exposure to risks from other threats, the need for food security and future livelihood versus the risk of injury. The objective of villagers in conflict areas is to somehow balance the multitude of risks they face on a daily basis in order to survive. As South (2012, p. 21) writes, "Self-protection and survival mechanisms often involve taking tough decisions... between safety and livelihood security. Many self-protection strategies expose vulnerable people to further risks." These further risks include the risk of losing crops, village stores of rice, and orchards, which are weighed against the risk of using landmines as a form of protection.

Obviously, the presence of landmines laid by the community itself brings with it the risk of accidents. When respondents to the KAP surveys were asked to list the kind of activities victims or survivors of explosions were engaged in when they had an accident, sixty-five per cent reported that accidents most commonly result from villagers entering mined areas to collect forest products (MRE WG 2014). Concerns for food security and daily survival override other factors.[13] As Bottomley (2001, p. 12) says, "The risk of not being able to feed a family or to secure land can sometimes only be addressed through undertaking a high risk activity" like navigating mined forests in search of produce.

Despite these risks, research conducted by Schissler (2016, p. 5) reported that communities expressed concern that though ceasefires improved freedom of movement, they had increased the number of business activities in former civil war areas. These activities may or may not have the support of the local communities. Feedback from six stakeholders in five states and regions in the east of Myanmar confirmed that the use of landmines as a means of community protection had not reduced significantly after ceasefires. Communities are retaining the use of landmines as a means to protect their resources from new threats from businesses and developers. Even with a series of bilateral and national ceasefires signed, local protection concerns remain, with one stakeholder stating bluntly that, "If we remove our landmines then our forest would be gone."[14] Another said, "It is